JAPAN AND KOREA



Building a turtle ship
Admiral Yi Sunshin himself inspects the progress and plans of the shipbuilders. The extraordinary armored turtle ships captured the Koreans' imagination, despite the fact that Yi's navy probably never had more than three of four of them at any one time.

JAPAN INVADED KOREA TWICE in the late 16th century, precipitating epic naval conflicts between two countries with very different seafaring traditions. Since the 1220s Japanese pirates had plagued the Korean coasts. This forced Korea to organize a naval defense system, with large, well-armed ships, to protect merchant convoys and coastal settlements. In Japan, by contrast, despite a thriving population of fishermen, pirates, and sea traders, naval development was limited. Accounts of Japan's long drawn out civil wars of the 16th century include few references to fighting on water. When Japan's warrior leader Toyotomi Hideyoshi mounted a large-scale invasion of Korea in 1592, he saw ships merely as troop transports. But for the Koreans their naval strength proved to be a trump card, allowing them to achieve decisive victories at sea that forced the Japanese invaders to withdraw in 1593 and again in 1598.

CHINESE ABSENCE

The naval war between Japan and Korea in the 1590s was fought without the intervention of the major regional power, China. Ming China was the most sophisticated, technologically advanced society in the world, but its decision, taken in the 15th century, to get rid of large warships and abandon long-distance voyages left a naval vacuum in Asian waters. Japanese pirates—known as *wako* ("dwarf raiders") to their victims—were free to raid China's defenseless coasts, while the Portuguese, once they were well established in the Indian Ocean, sought further trading opportunities in China and Japan. When Japan invaded Korea, the Chinese sent an army to support the Koreans, but, because of their naval weakness, only intervened on a small scale in the conflict at sea.

JAPANESE SEA POWER

The Japanese were able to assemble a fleet large enough to transport 160,000 soldiers to Korea in 1592. The fleet consisted chiefly of pirate or merchant vessels turned to military use. For sea

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

TURTLE SHIP

The turtle ship, or *kobukson,* was a variant on the *panokseon*, the Korean cannon-armed warship, comparable to a Mediterranean galleass. Admiral Yi Sunshin is credited with reviving the design, which had been tried out experimentally almost two centuries earlier. The first of Admiral Yi's turtle ships was launched in March 1592, just as the Japanese invasion of Korea began. Its most original feature was the covered upper deck, shielded with iron plates and spikes—thought to resemble a turtle's shell. This protected the crew from missiles and, more importantly, made the ship impossible to take by boarding. The impressive array of cannon fired out of portholes, with two at the prow, one at the stern, and possibly 10 along each side. A cannon may also have been placed to fire from the dragon's head. The oars, each pulled by eight men, permitted rapid maneuver in combat. The turtle ships' role in the war between Korea and Japan has often been exaggerated—only three were built at the time, possibly because iron was in short supply.

Replica turtle ship
Korea's Naval Academy Museum houses this life-sized replica of a turtle ship, one of a number that have been built in the country. There is even one replica that is regularly sailed on a lake.

